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THE HINDU



Chettinad pride comes alive at the fifth edition of its annual heritage festival **P2**

***BATHTHA*: THE EIGHTIES COME ALIVE P4**

As *Dorothy* wins over audiences, members of the queer community speak about seeing their lives, desires, and struggles reflected with tenderness on screen



Finding euphoria

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(This article may contain spoilers for Dorothy*)*

"This does not feel like a step up; it feels like having stepped on an escalator." This is how Jaya, a trans activist and general manager of Sahodaran, an NGO working to uplift LGBTQIA+ people, describes how Tamil filmmaker Karthik Subbaraj's latest sensation, *Dorothy*, feels to the queer community.

Dorothy, released in theatres on September 25, tells a sensitive story about a trans woman coming into her own and, as a bonus, finding love. The film has gotten rave reviews and, most importantly, appreciation from many in the community, who have yearned for decades for Tamil cinema to open its arms and embrace them.

Actor and author Negha Shahin is over the moon. "We have finally gotten a film that takes a deep look into trans life. It surprised me to see how even cisgender heteronormative people connected to the film." The emotion is apparent when Marakkah, teacher, poet, theatre artiste and founder of Chennai Queer Library, says she saw herself in *Dorothy*. "All my old memories came back to me. I couldn't stop crying during the last 30 minutes," she says.

Malini Jeevarathnam, actor-filmmaker and activist, found *Dorothy* to be a deep, well-crafted film. "It's a raw, real story about what happens next door in our towns. What I liked was how they didn't compromise on authenticity for aesthetic quality," they say.

How Karthik's story shed light on the prevalent social evil of honour killings targeting trans persons seems to have touched everyone. "We have seen honour killings due to caste and religion, and we are, in fact, a society that killed female infants. But Karthik has exposed something people don't wish to speak about," says Marakkah. Negha herself is a victim of family violence, "which is why I found that aspect of *Dorothy* to be very valid," she says.

No place for horror

In the film, the titular Dorothy is also seen to be suffering from immense gender dysphoria before her transition – something mainstream Tamil cinema has hardly touched upon. "Most trans women, like myself, could indulge in feminine activities secretly to feel euphoric. But some others may not get to do that. They might suppress those feelings due to fear and follow the stereotypes their parents taught them. However, the feeling tends to burst out of them eventually, which is what *Dorothy* shows," says Jaya, who also rejoices in how "sensitively and tenderly Karthik has showed the feeling of euphoria after transition".

That said, the community is also witnessing all the queerphobia that is being spewed at them these past few weeks. "There's a common notion that Tamil people have accepted trans people and that they see trans people as gods. So if these people are reacting like this to a film like *Dorothy*, I wonder how they would react if they showed gay men, lesbian women, and so on," wonders Negha.

The film's final shot, featuring a kiss between a cis man and a trans woman, has particularly received vile, inhumane remarks online. Jaya finds it strange that people confuse the film's queer identity with homosexuality. She wonders what is so grotesque about the kiss when cis-men have always sexualised trans women. "There are many trans sex workers; now who indulges in sex with them? People should understand that trans people have their own romantic and sexual desires and dreams of a future with their loved one. And the way *Dorothy* speaks of that is beautiful," Jaya says.

Malini adds that accepting trans identity but refusing to accept trans romance comes from a faulty political lens. "It's as if they are giving acceptance due to pity, but nobody needs that. If you accept me, accept who I am, who I love and how I live," she says.

Now, even as we feel delighted seeing *Dorothy*, it may not be a smooth-sailing experience for trans women wishing to catch the film in theatres. "Even today, there's eve-teasing and a nasty gaze towards us," says Negha.

A warm embrace Sananth and Rishikanth in *Dorothy;* (below, clockwise from top left) Marakkah, Jaya, Negha Shahin, and Malini Jeevarathnam. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



> ***Dorothy will not influence a cis woman or a cis man, but it will give confidence, courage, validation, and healing to those who carry that feeling within them***
>
> **MARAKKAH**
> Teacher, poet, theatre artiste

Marakkah hopes the need to normalise trans lives changes. "I always believe that the day someone walking on the road sees and passes by us just like another human being on the street, we will know that society has changed," she says. Jaya mentions that a lot has changed over the last 20 years, but there's a long way to go. "Trans women are in a lot of fields, and there's more awareness about trans men. So more advocacy and lobbying will bring about more change," she believes.

Mirror to society

Cinema, our sources agree, plays a huge part. "Art form is something that directly meets people, and so how you show us on screen matters because that's how society will accept us," says Marakkah. *Dorothy*, interestingly, features trans woman actor Jeeva Subramanian in a pivotal role. Negha says this may not guarantee more opportunities for trans actors. "It's been four years since I won the Kerala State Film Award. But not many doors have opened for me since." But the fact that Karthik took Jeeva to the Toronto International Film Festival, where the film premiered, gives Negha some hope. "Usually, they would cast trans people for a miserable role, and they wouldn't even invite us for audio launches or promotions."

Of course, many community members are also mentioning a few flaws in *Dorothy*. Negha wishes the makers had added a disclaimer urging people not to use the slurs used in the film. But she does not wish to nitpick it as a major flaw. Malini says that while we can criticise any film, when it comes to queer cinema, even the act of criticism is shaped by privilege. "In 100 years of cinema, how many films reflect the lives of people? So we don't want to nitpick. Because, at the end of the day, a parent or a young man watching the film should get this understanding."

These days, only the privileged seem comfortable in a theatre seat, they add. "The oppressed think twice before clapping. That's been the state of cinema. To be able to sit in a theatre seat comfortably with pride and claim that this is our film is quite something."

Naked ambition

Indie-rock quartet The F16s talks about growing older, posing in the buff for its new album cover, and learning to trust its instincts

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Three years ago, Chennai-based indie alternative rock band The F16s went to Ooty and stripped down. Literally. For almost a month in 2023, Harshan Radhakrishnan, Joshua "Josh" Fernandez, Sashank Manohar and Abhinav Krishnaswamy lived together in the hills, making music, playing together, and eventually taking their clothes off in Nature. The resulting photograph – four grown men, naked and unbothered – became the cover of the 10-track *All Dogs Go To Heaven*, their second full-length album, out October 21, 10 years after their first album, *Triggerpunkte*. It is an apt image for a record that feels like The F16s have stripped away some of the machinery around making music and, in the process, found themselves sounding freer.

Joshua, lead vocalist and guitarist, says the idea came from what dogs represented to them: instinct, purity and a lack of judgement. The photograph, like much of the album, was not heavily planned. "It sort of wrote itself, sort of shot itself, sort of named itself," he says. Even the title came unusually easily.

Homecoming

The F16s have spent nearly 13 years moving around their own sound. *Triggerpunkte*, released in 2016, was a young band's energetic collision of influences; the EPs that followed – *WKND FRNDS* in 2019 and *Is It Time To Eat The Rich Yet?* in 2021 – pushed further into synths, psychedelia and danceable territory. There have been solo projects and stretches of working apart, too. By the time they came together for this album, they were not particularly interested in asking what the next The F16s record was supposed to sound like.

"Age just sort of softens you naturally," Joshua says. After years of playing together, the four musicians have developed what he describes as a kind of shared wavelength. The new record reflects that: it is mellower and more cohesive than *Triggerpunkte*.

Harshan wanted to capture the particular chemistry of the four musicians playing together in a room. Previous recordings could be fragmented, with one person coming in to record guitar and another arriving later for bass. In Ooty, everyone played together.

"We've never gone forward with an album thinking it has to sound this way," Abhinav says. Deciding in advance that it should be heavy, psychedelic or anything else, he argues, only puts the band in a box. So they took the equipment they had, borrowed or bought what they needed, and made it work.

The entire album was subsequently mixed by Harshan at his home studio in Chennai. That detail matters because this is the first The F16s album they feel they have made almost completely themselves.



Punk? Indeed The F16s. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The sound

You can hear the difference in the singles. 'Mt. Whateverest' is still unmistakably The F16s but less interested in racing towards the next beat. 'LMAO' is proof that growing older has not compelled them to become solemn. And then there is 'Little Mama's Boy', which initially sounds like a cheeky maternal refrain into something stranger – affection, expectation and a lifetime's worth of parental approval compressed into two words. Even their relationship to the band has changed. Joshua describes coming back to The F16s after individual projects as "coming home to your person" – a relationship with its own affection and scrutiny.

It is perhaps why the naked album cover does not feel like a gimmick. It instead, strips down to the bare essentials.

All Dogs Go To Heaven *releases on major streaming platforms on October 21.*



Showcasing opulence (Clockwise from left) Kreeda - a Bharatanatyam group presents traditional childhood games; Yali x Ashdeen: The Theatre of Textile; staff recreate typical scenes from Chettiar life in the mansions; and Meenakshi Meyyappan, key organiser. SAI SANJAY AND PADAIYAPPA

Chettinad in business

The Chettinad Heritage and Cultural Festival finds new ways to draw attention to the region's architecture, crafts and traditions

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Sometimes a revival looks like a family wedding: fleets of cars, precise handwritten notes, a staccato of urgent phone calls and the luxurious rustle of silk saris.

At the bougainvillea-framed The Bangala in Karaikudi, on the eve of the Chettinad Heritage and Cultural Festival, the formidable Mrs Meenakshi Meyyappan sits at the centre of it all. A room in her relaxed boutique hotel has been converted into a temporary control room, jostling with books, cardboard boxes and friends-turned-volunteers.

At 92, she has been up early every morning for months, working out the festival schedule, personally inviting speakers and guests, planning daily menus and overseeing room allotments. In the five years that it has run, the festival has brought tourism, attention and change to Chettinad, introducing the rest of the country to the treasures of this unique arid landscape, punctuated by sprawling, extravagant mansions.

Comprising 75 villages and spread over about 600 square miles, the region is home to the Nattukottai Chettiar community, that did business across South-East Asia and poured their profits into lavish mansions spanning 40,000 square feet and more between the 18th and mid-20th centuries. Over the past decade, as the mansions began to be torn down, it became clear that Chettinad needed attention if it was to survive.

There were about 15,000 mansions at its peak, and while no one is sure how many remain, M Meyyappan Jr, Meenakshi Meyyappan's son who compiled *A Chettiar Album* with the late historian S Muthiah, says most of these homes only come alive during weddings and functions. "Many stand empty today, and the knowledge and skills required to maintain them are disappearing with every generation. Effectively Chettinad is shrinking."

The festival has already brought change, with more people discovering the region for holidays and weddings. That interest is translating into investment. The Park Hotels opened The Vaadhyar's House restaurant after restoring a 150-year-old dilapidated mansion in 2018. They launched The Lotus Palace opposite it in 2024, in a 230-year-old structure, offering guests a Kanadukathan-meets-The-Gatsby vibe. Now, locals say Taj Hotels has been looking for a mansion to restore as well.

The community is also welcoming tourists. Jewellery designer Meenu Subbiah from the Chettiar community, launched Pettagam, India's first private museum for Chettinad jewellery last year. And Visalakshi Ramaswamy, the influential revivalist, recently launched The Museum of Chettinad in her 125-year-old family home in Kanadukathan.

We weave our way through the museum, admiring her striking collection of embellished Ravi Varma prints, Burmese lacquerware and Chettinad silk saris with their signature contrasting borders. Visalakshi Ramaswamy is disarmingly candid about why she opened it: "We have lost so much information. I'm 80 years old and I don't know that much." She adds, "I have the house. I have the rooms. So I decided to do it here... If you know what you did in the past, you see today with better clarity."

On the schedule

The festival included a feisty conversation on politics between Shashi Tharoor and author-historian Manu Pillai; an evocative display by Ally Matthen's Registry of Sarees in collaboration with textile revivalist Ashdeen Lilaowala and researcher Peter Lee; and an inspiring call to arms by historian Malvika Singh, an advocate of Indian handicraft and founding member of Rehwa, encouraging attendees to buy from weavers.





Also, between visiting Soundara Nayaki Kailasanatha and Kandadevi temple led by author-historian Pradeep Chakravarthy, and exploring the Zamindar House in Devakottai and the Chettinad Palace, we realise the magnitude of artisanal skill that has disappeared over generations.

Architect Benny Kuriakose and Visalakshi Ramaswamy, for example, have collaborated on reviving architectural techniques, including the Athangudi tile. Benny says that there were three or four establishments making the tiles when they started research a few decades ago. Now there are 300 factories across Chettinad.

On the final night of the festival, over The Bangla's addictive fried quail and lacy appams, Ashdeen Lilaowala, who has revived the Parsi gara sari and inspired a new generation of artisans by embracing change, says it is important to take craft traditions forward. "If we want to employ more and more artisans, we need to expand. By doing this we have managed to get the second generation working," he says.

The day after the festival, Meenakshi Meyyappan is at home, but still busy. "Someone always wants something done," she says with her trademark composure, adding, "I don't mind. Organising is one of my core strengths." The year's edition is done, but the work continues.

Old recipes are being rediscovered and taught, while tile makers, jewellers and weavers master traditional techniques to find fresh audiences, and new pride.

The Chettinad Heritage and Cultural Festival is more than four days of showcasing a community. It is proof that change can begin with just a few people. Starting with a 92-year-old *aachi* who is already on the phone planning the next edition, between deciding the lunch menu for her guests – including actor Mammootty.

Making each mile count

Get set to race as Chennai Runs returns, bringing runners together for a cause

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How to reach the finish line is probably the lingering thought of every marathon runner. But at Chennai Runs, scheduled for November 1, every mile carries a little more weight, as thousands of runners gather not just to clock the distance, but to run for a cause.

Hosted by Madras Round Table 1 (MRT1), the fifth edition of Chennai Runs will support The Spastics Society of Tamil Nadu, which focusses on inclusive education and rehabilitation for children with disabilities.

"Just like in the previous editions, all the money raised will go towards charity. We are expecting around 11,500 to 12,000 participants this year," says Shray Rattha, chairman, MRT1.

The marathon will take runners through some of Chennai's familiar stretches, including Marina Beach, Santhome and Besant Nagar.

"Like every year, this year will also see the participation of children with disabilities, who will take part in the 1 km run," Shray adds.



On your mark Participants at Chennai Runs 2025. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The marathon has four main categories – 21 km, 10 km, 5 km and 3 km. The 3 km has seen several children, particularly those between the ages of 10 and 15, taking part with their parents. Teenagers and families often opt for the 5 km and 10 km, while the 21 km draws experienced runners and members of running clubs from across the city.

Subbu Venkatachalam, who has been a participant in the marathon for the past three years, says what sets Chennai Runs apart is the cause behind the event. "Running for a cause makes it different," he says.

"For participants, a marathon is also a chance to experience the city differently – running through its scenic roads while being part of a larger community. It brings the them together," he adds.

The fifth edition of Chennai Runs will be held on November 1. Register at chennairuns.com.

Challenging the gaze

Meet the women behind the lavani through a documentary theatre challenging misconceptions about art and the artiste

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A woman in a nine-yard sari, anklets tinkling as she dances to the beat of the dholki – for many, this is the image of lavani. But how much do we really know about the woman behind that image?

This will be the central question of *Lavanyavati* (a performer of lavani), a documentary theatre production by Kali Billi Productions which will be performed at The Lab @ Shanta on October 1.

Lavani, an art form from Maharashtra, was traditionally performed by women from communities such as Bhatu kolhati, Kalwat and Dombari, many of whom are from nomadic or OBC (Other Backward Class) communities. Historically, while the performers have mostly been women, in spaces such as tamasha and sangeet bari, the audiences have largely been men from dominant communities.



Dancing queens Savitri Medhatul performing lavani. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Years ago, when Savitri Medhatul, founder, Kali Billi Productions, began researching lavani, she realised that its portrayal in popular culture was skewed, with lavanyavatis often being labelled as vulgar or perceived as the 'other woman'. She felt this narrative needed to change.



Savitri along with a team of four, will be performing at the Lavanyavati.

"To counter such fictional narratives woven around lavani artistes, the production has been built around research, oral histories, interviews and personal narratives, using a non-fiction format," says Savitri, explaining the choice of documentary theatre.

"Lavanyavatis have been perceived either as vamps or victims. I wanted to challenge both these ideas and show that lavani women are independent, intelligent, and artistic entrepreneurs. The problem was never the women, but the larger patriarchal society," she says.

For her, encountering traditional lavani artistes through the dramatised stage performance and conversation, is key to changing perceptions of the form.

"Once you meet traditional lavani artistes, you understand that the portrayal of them in popular media is wrong. But it is important to have that encounter."

"Everybody talks about the pride of lavani, but nobody talks about the sustenance of these artistes," says Savitri, adding that Government support and patronage are necessary if the traditional form is to survive.

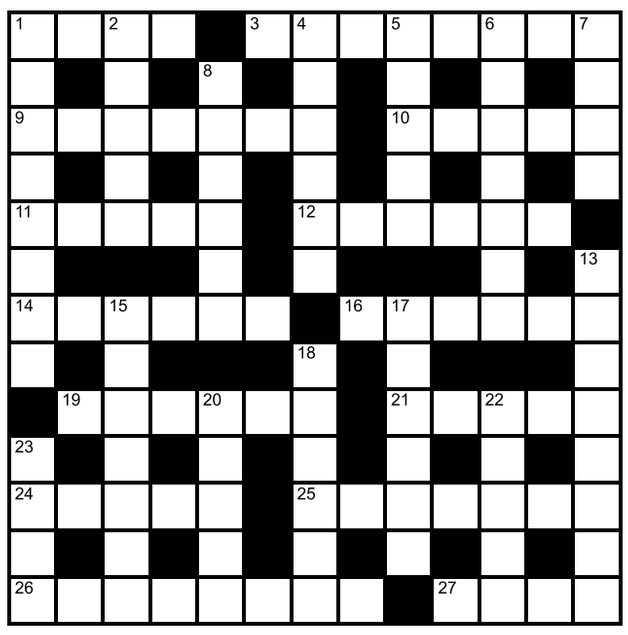
Over the years, Savitri has also observed positive changes in the way lavani has accessed and perceived. The form is no longer confined to the communities that have traditionally performed it, with lavani workshops drawing people from diverse backgrounds across Maharashtra. The growing interest in learning and performing the form, she says, offers hope for its sustenance.

Through *Lavanyavati*, she hopes to take that conversation further. "It's like a domino effect. Through the performance, I hope it will spark more conversations about lavani keeping it alive," she says.

Lavanyavati, a documentary theatre production by Kali Billi Productions, will be presented at The Lab@Shanta on Thursday, October 1, at 7pm.

METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD 73

(Set by Doppelganger)



Across

1 Location (4)
3 Predict (8)
9 Not knowing (7)
10 Walk (5)
11 Surplus (5)
12 Mother's sister (6)
14 Relating to cultural group (6)
16 Tropical fruit (6)
19 Once a part of USSR (6)
21 Threw (5)
24 Not dead (5)
25 Machine commonly seen in offices (7)
26 Proposes (8)
27 Cipher (4)

Down

1 Compressed (8)
2 Browned bread (5)
4 Theatrical presentations (6)
5 Consumed (5)
6 Name for the U.S. (7)
7 Periodic event in oceans (4)
8 Island State of 6D (6)
13 Australian marsupial (8)
15 Buildings for people to live in (7)
17 Liaison (6)
18 Rug (6)
20 Vista (5)
22 Set free (5)
23 Sets down (4)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

Solution No. 73







Indian couture (Left) Outfits from the new collection Sutura; (inset) designer Amritha Ram, the label's creative director. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Beyond the loom

Designer Amritha Ram is pushing the boundaries of Indian textiles at KH House of Khadar

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At the Runway Seven Fashion Awards in New York, a feature film accompanied KH House of Khadar's showcase of its latest collection Sutura. The clatter of wooden looms and the rhythm of weavers at work set the stage and the mood before the models clad in khadi began walking. At the awards on September 14, the label won in the Best Ready-to-Wear Collection category.

KH House of Khadar takes khadi beyond its familiar associations with handloom and sustainability, and places it firmly in a language of contemporary fashion. For Amritha Ram, the label's creative director, the fabric is a canvas that can be shaped and reimagined without losing its identity.

"We did not want to carry the preconceived notion that comes with khadi. Sometimes, a fabric comes with a tag, and letting go of it takes a very long time. We considered it just as a canvas, and it is up to the artist approaching it to decide whether they are going to do charcoal, oil or something else," she says.

For Amritha, this meant moving away from the familiar visual language of khadi and exploring how the fabric could find a place in global fashion. The latest collection, Sutura, puts that idea into practice, challenging the perception that khadi must look a certain way.

The new collection brings together undyed khadi in its natural colour, khadi denim, and vegetable leather. Rather than leaning on traditional silhouettes, the pieces explore how the fabric can be shaped into contemporary, wearable designs. "The whole idea when we wanted to present it in New York was that it should connect with people. We wanted to create something that was neither exactly couture nor streetwear, but a blend that would actually connect with people," she says.



At KH House of Khadar, fabric collaborations are opening up new ways to work with the textile without compromising on sustainability. The label has experimented with tencel and is exploring sustainable lycra blends that could expand the structural possibilities of khadi. "Today, fabric has gone beyond emotions and boundaries into science, and that is very exciting," she says, adding that as a designer, the possibility to explore fabric collaborations without compromising on sustainability is important.

Coming up

For the next chapter for KH House of Khadar, Amritha is working on a collection centred on couture, an entirely new territory for the label. "It has been challenging, but this is very exciting. As much as I look forward to every single collection of mine, this is something I am really looking forward to presenting," she says.

Alongside fashion, Amritha continues to work on film costumes, a practice that she approaches differently from designing for the runway. She is currently working on *Kalki 2*, with portions featuring Kamal Haasan already underway, and two more films under Raaj Kamal Films International are in the pipeline.

"Both are things I love doing: fashion and films. When it comes to films, it depends on the entire team, what the character requires and what you want to give. With fashion, it is up to what you want to give to the world of fashion." Balancing the two, she says, keeps her in a happy space.

Brewing happy mornings

Ravi master, known for his impeccable filter coffee at Saravana Bhavan, now serves from a coffee truck at Hotel Maris



A cup of comfort Ravi master inside the coffee truck at Hotel Maris, Chennai. JOHAN SATHYADAS

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Spiderman weaves a web to save people. Superman flies to save the Earth.

This 'coffee man' uses decoction and milk to make mornings bearable.

Ravichandran N – or Ravi master, as he is fondly called – is a legend in Chennai's coffee circles. For hundreds of runners and joggers who hit Chennai's Marina beach in the early hours of the morning, his piping hot, frothy filter coffee at the Saravana Bhavan outlet on Radhakrishnan Salai has long been a source of comfort and warmth.

With that popular outlet having shut down, Ravi master has found a new home: at a coffee truck parked in Hotel Maris, Cathedral Road.

"He (Ravi master) gives us the world's best coffee every morning," says Saravanan Palaniappan, a textile businessman.

Now, Ravi's day typically starts at 4am, when he opens the colourful, snazzy coffee truck – called 'First Cup at Maris' – that has started functioning in the last couple of months. "It's heartening to see so many people come here for my coffee. There is no secret recipe to the drink I make; it's all about having the right proportion of milk and decoction," says Ravi.

Beyond the taste of the coffee, Ravi's endearing nature has helped build lasting loyalty. "Having seen some of these regular walkers for many years, I know their preference and how each of them likes their morning coffee," says Ravi.

Over the past two decades, Ravi's special skills have drawn patrons not just from the nearby Poes Garden and Kasturi Rangan Road, but also from across the city. Here, over coffee and cookies, they chat about everything under the sun, from politics to cinema and sports.

"I like to call it 'community coffee'," says Sankaranarayanan V, a 54-year-old IT software professional who is passionate about strength training and fitness, "The things that we discuss over coffee gives us enough fuel to go through our tasks for the day at office and home."

The coffee truck, stationed in the parking area at Hotel Maris, is hard to miss due to its quirky illustrations. These ideas and sketches are the handiwork of popular illustrator Bhavya Desai. "I had to come here for a few days in the morning just to understand the target audience," explains Bhavya, who was commissioned by Anand Rengaswami, the present managing director of the hotel and grandson of founder Maria Pillai, for the task, "I wanted to weave an entire story using illustrations depicting the 4am to 7am period of the day. You'll see people having a hearty time, discussing business or some even on a date. A lot of things get done over a cup of coffee." And when that coffee is made by Ravi master, they certainly do.

The coffee truck is open from 4am to 7am at Hotel Maris, Cathedral Road. Coffee is priced at ₹50, while mini coffee and tea are priced at ₹30.





Retro trip A still from *Baththa*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Don of all trades

Director Balaji Tharaneetharan speaks about his latest film *Baththa* and Vijay Sethupathi's evolution as an actor over the years

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"A filmmaker who gave a debut film like *Naduvula Konjam Pakkatha Kaanom* should have ideally done many films and be in a different league now." This comment was posted under a promo for writer-director Balaji Tharaneetharan's upcoming film, *Baththa*, starring Vijay Sethupathi, and the sentiment is not hard to understand.

Balaji has had an interesting career trajectory; after delivering a blockbuster debut with *NKPK* in 2012, he began working on his second film, *Seethakaathi*, but paused the project temporarily and started *Oru Pakka Kathai* in 2014. But as fate would have it, *Seethakaathi* was released in 2018; subsequently, *Oru Pakka Kathai* was released directly on streaming in 2020, after lying in the cans for over four years due to financial issues.

And now, after eight long years, Balaji is bringing a film to the big screen this week.

Balaji's *Baththa*, set to release on October 1, is a story set in North Madras in the 1980s about a local gangster. However, it isn't your usual gangster actioner. "It's a drama about the human being within this don. Another character prevents us from seeing Baththa as the person he is and makes us see him as the gangster that he appears to be," explains Balaji, adding that he took inspiration from the people and incidents he witnessed in his early years. "I grew up in Triplicane until the age of seven, and that neighbourhood defined the world in my mind. And that was the inspiration for *Baththa*."

Recreating the Eighties was an enjoyable process for Balaji. "I was born then, and so that period is very personal to me. And everyone, especially art director T Muthuraj, supported my vision a lot." Interestingly, Balaji wanted to move away from how North Madras is usually depicted. "I wanted to recreate some outer areas of North Madras, like Old Kaladipet. Usually, they would show areas near the shore, but I didn't want to do that."

Baththa is also Balaji's third collaboration with Vijay Sethupathi after *NKPK* and *Seethakaathi*, and the director seems quite happy with how the star has evolved over the years. "He has always been a director-friendly and sensible actor. He would never try to imitate another actor. He would observe common people and take inspiration, but he would make it his own and do what's required for the character." During *Baththa*, Balaji realised that Vijay had a deeper understanding of the craft. "He is constantly trying to grow, be it the way he sees cinema or the way he approaches the craft."



I like* The Godfather *a lot, apart from all of Martin Scorsese's gangster films. I also like* Road to Perdition, Gangs of Wasseypur, *and Ram Gopal Varma's* Satya. *However,* Baththa *wouldn't be your usual gangster film. It's a drama about a gangster

BALAJI THARANEETHARAN

Baththa has music scored by recent sensation Sai Abhyankkar, who, Balaji says, has a good understanding of music. "Also, I think his indie work does not fully reflect his palette. For instance, he spoke highly of Balu Mahendra's *Veedu* and about many old songs that he likes. And if you explain a mood to him, he would easily imbibe it and compose tracks," adds the filmmaker.

Though he finished another script along with *Baththa*, Balaji would have to start afresh for his next. "I gave that second script to a friend, and I have asked him to direct it." But Balaji knows the audiences want to see more of his films sooner. "I understand I have been taking a long time to make films. Even I want to do my next film as soon as I can."

Baththa *releases in theatres today*

'A kids' film for grown-ups'

Fahadh Faasil chats about how magic and fantasy are woven into his upcoming *Don't Trouble The Trouble*

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It is rare to see actor-producer Fahadh Faasil partake in media interactions. "I have been hearing this a lot," he says with a laugh, when he walks in to meet a small group of journalists at the production house, Arka Media Works' office in Hyderabad. His new Telugu film, *Don't Trouble The Trouble,* is poised to release on October 2. "It feels as though this is my first (Telugu) film. So I wanted to come and introduce myself," Fahadh says.

But Fahadh is no stranger to Telugu cinema. He became a household name portraying the antagonist, Bhanwar Singh Shekawat, in the *Pushpa* films.

DTTT, written and directed by Shashank Yeleti and co-produced by SS Karthikeya and Shobu Yarlagadda from the *Baahubali* team, gets its title from a famous dialogue by actor Balakrishna. "There's something in the story that spells trouble, hence the title," says Fahadh.

Two scripts a year

Fahadh reveals that on an average, he listens to only two script narrations a year. "Back home in Malayalam cinema, the drama is subtle. In this, there are elements of magic and fantasy woven around the core idea of concern and love. I did not want to miss this opportunity."

The film was shot across 79 locations, including crowded pockets of Cyberabad and Hyderabad's industrial exhibition, Numaish. Fahadh is aware of the fun reels put up by a few movie buffs who watched the shooting. "Almost all my Malayalam films have been shot on location. *Pushpa* is a rare film I shot on a set. I enjoy filming on location and the production took care of crowd control."

DTTT revolves around Fahadh's character named Suri, child actor Ssara Palekar and a beagle. A mention of magical powers and invisibility may evoke memories of *Mr India*. Fahadh describes it as "a kids' film for grown-ups. I hope the film can make people realise a few things they had neglected at some point in their lives."

As a producer, he is pleased with the reception to *Bethlehem Kudumba Unit*. He knew intuitively that the film would be received well, but was surprised by the overwhelming response. His trust in director Girish AD is evident when he speaks about the film and their earlier collaboration on *Premalu*. "I do not always go by the script, since I think there must be some room for change. I am particular about the structure: the beginning, middle and the end. During *Premalu*, as the film progressed Girish would show us the footage and we would all discuss." Fahadh equates producing a film to playing a cricket match. "We don't know if we will win but it's fun to play the game."



Making magic Fahadh Faasil and child actor Ssara Palekar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nature heals

All about *The Hornbill Promise*, an upcoming wildlife documentary by Safique Hazarika and Vinod K Reddy



Call of the Wild *The Hornbill Promise* tells the story of Tara and Tenzing, a pair of rare hornbills. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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From a distance, the rugged slopes of the Eastern Himalaya look pristine: mist-swathed, gelid-peaked and canopy-covered. But the moment you get closer or focus through a long lens, you cannot help but see humans everywhere, says wildlife photographer Safique Hazarika, who firmly believes that "unless humans emotionally or spiritually integrate with Nature, saving Nature will be difficult."

This premise lies at the core of *The Hornbill Promise*, an upcoming wildlife documentary from Wildora Film , a Hyderabad-based production house focussed on the natural world. Set in Latpanchar, West Bengal, in the Eastern Himalaya, the film tells the story of Tara and Tenzing, a pair of rare rufous-necked hornbills, capturing both their relationship as well as the people who inhabit the region.

Safique, who co-directed and co-produced the film with Vinod K Reddy, says the idea emerged from a trip to Latpanchar a couple of years ago. "I always wanted to photograph the rufous-necked hornbills because they are so exotic, beautiful and unusual-looking," he says. Additionally, they carry deep spiritual meaning in many cultures and exhibit a range of fascinating behaviours. For instance, "they partner for life," says Safique, an ardent wildlife photographer with over 17 years of experience.

They spent the next two-and-a-half years shooting this 45-minute-long film, which is currently in production and will be out in February 2027. A 10-minute short and the trailer have already been released. "The entire journey was back-breaking," laughs Safique, recalling the challenges of shooting at a 7,000-foot altitude, including trekking many kilometres to reach the hornbills, grappling with leeches and rain, and waiting interminably to spot interesting behaviours. "It was very difficult, but we were convinced that we were going to get a life cycle. And we needed that to tell an inspiring story," he says.

The film, which doesn't just chronicle the lifecycle of these birds but also features interviews with locals and experts, has been voiced over by Dia Mirza. The duo firmly believes that creating a narrative that centres on a single pair of hornbills, almost anthropomorphising them, will help people care more about this bird. "We wanted to train people's minds to want to have this species around forever. Science often vanishes, but feeling stays," says Safique.

